

“All Names are Pseudonyms”: A Critical Reflection on Pseudonymizing Names in HCI

“All Names are Pseudonyms”

Nana Kesewaa, NKD, and Dankwa

Gender Diversity in Informatic Systems, University of Kassel
nkthankwa@uni-kassel.de

ABSTRACT

A person’s name embodies identity. During user studies in Human Computer Interaction (HCI), persons are often renamed (pseudonymization) to hide their identity for privacy and ethical reasons. Pseudonymization occurs mostly as a “silent” affair of due diligence. Researchers barely give substantial information to the process nor reveal a reflexive position nor acknowledge the underlying elements of power and identity negotiation. As HCI advances in mitigating the design of biased technologies and breaking oppressive structures, I argue, in this paper, the need for the field to re-consider research requirements such as pseudonymization as possible to embody oppressive structures and erase identity. I present a review of papers from the 2020 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI ‘20) that illustrate how silent the HCI approach is. My argument is built on Critical Race Theory, questioning the objectivity of such technical requirements. I use personal narratives to bolster this argument, ending with a call to the HCI community to acknowledge the power and privilege in renaming participants with three recommendations for consideration.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human Centered Computing; • Human Computer Interaction; • HCI theory, concepts, and models;

KEYWORDS

Critical Race Theory, Pseudonymization, Counter Story Telling, Negotiation

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1 INTRODUCTION

“In 1951 we moved to Constantia; the house wasn’t large but the address was right- we’d made it. Alberta came to work for us. Her name was really Bathandwa, but my mother asked if we could call her Alberta; she liked the name, although she never explained why. Bathandwa seemed to agree.” [22]

The purpose of a person’s name is multi-faceted. Apart from referential purposes, there exists a connection between a person’s name and identity construction [1]. A name as an identity constructor is connected to facets such as race, religion, ethnicity, and gender. A name builds on the intrinsic and extrinsic relations of a person and the society they live in. The social power inherent in a name and its capacity to shape the life course of the person becomes most evident when the name given is negative [21]. In research, a participant’s real name may be obliterated when reporting on research about them. The practice is founded on principles of confidentiality, the protection of identity and ethics.

Pseudonymization is the act of replacing real or family given names (orthonyms) with fictitious names (pseudonyms) for a particular objective. The primary goal for pseudonyms is to achieve anonymity: the inability to link participant’s data to their person. In literature, in the seventeenth centuries, authors used pseudonyms to protect themselves from readers, women writers to escape criticism and protect their reputation [12] and in today’s internet social network platforms, users are permitted pseudonyms to allow free expression and facilitate non-identifiable content [11]. Researchers use pseudonyms to ensure confidentiality and anonymity. Though anonymity in research is argued as a thing rarely achievable, pseudonyms are accepted as an integral part, almost ubiquitous in the process [13].

In HCI, pseudonyms are used extensively with the similar goal of protecting participants, erasing the possibility of being traced back due to the provided research data. It is done to enable participants, in safety, share their experiences, satisfy ethical and data protection requirements, and provide participant privacy and confidentiality. Pseudonymization is recognized as a technical requirement, a thing that gets checked off the list. The process provides little to no consideration of the need for negotiation or the recognition of the inherent complexity of identity behind the names. Negotiation in this sense is a process where parties actively and collectively agree and or compromise to the goal at hand for mutual benefit and fairness. The re-assigning of a name or renaming of a person is a process of identity negotiation [9]. The name-giver’s power and voice takes precedence over that of the name-taker. Renaming is more than a technical requirement [9, 13] and entrenched in

Eurocentric definitions of privacy and confidentiality. It thus fails to achieve elements of collective ownership of work, protection, privacy, and confidentiality when applied as a “one-size-fits all” approach.

In this paper, I call the attention of the HCI research community to pseudonymization and other “integral” research phases as we increase engagement with marginalized communities and perform cross-cultural work. I ask that pseudonymization is not treated as a technical thing (an established truth) but subjected to reflection and questioning. I argue that this is a research step where participants need to be actively involved, their identity preserved, and their voices amplified as positively as possible. I use voice in this paper acknowledging the interdependency and dynamic nature of voice and the need for research to facilitate voice and agency but not give voice [34]. I make a call for us to be other-conscious and ensure that translations of experience are not muddled under technicalities founded on colonialist ideologies. This is particularly essential as HCI advances in work that is cross-cultural and with marginalized groups.

I reveal my understanding of the pseudonymization process in the HCI community as a “silent activity”, hardly described or discussed as relevant to identity, power, or privilege. This understanding is based on a review of fifty papers from the 2020 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI '20). I use storytelling, a Critical Race Theory (CRT) tool, to share my personal narrative as a black researcher in Germany and an Akan. I emphasize the significance of names among the Akan and take a reflective position on my user research work. I argue that the act of renaming does not have to be fixed in stone and may very well be done to meet White standards of conformity. There is the need for HCI researchers to acknowledge the power and privilege that occurs and as such tailor goals of research to counter voice erasure and silencing. In addition, in cross-cultural research, the culture's concept of privacy and confidence should take primacy.

As HCI research veers towards critical perspectives of practice, steering away from oppressive westernized methodologies and increasing user research with persons from e.g., indigenous backgrounds or racial backgrounds, I hope that this paper stirs up discussion on the practice of pseudonymization and the recommendations presented are considered by practitioners. This paper contributes as well to the small corpus on race and ethnicity in HCI [19].

2 THE USE OF PSEUDONYMS IN HCI

Pseudonymization in HCI stems from social research practices where researchers are responsible for protecting participants' privacy, ensuring that data provided cannot be traced to participants, assigning them aliases or numbers [6]. Ethical and data protection requirements may place responsibility on researchers to provide confidentiality and anonymity. The provision of a safe space where participants are assured of privacy in sharing experiences. To gain an overview of current HCI practice, I conducted a review of scholarly work on the ACM Digital Library concentrating on CHI '20. I wanted to understand, using the most recent publications, how pseudonymization was performed. The search was based on an inquiry for research work that used “pseudonym*” anywhere in the paper. The search resulted in 65 papers. I reviewed the papers

by reading through them and selected 50 papers based on the following criterion: they had used a form of the word “pseudonym” to refer to the renaming of participants in a research study.

Of the 50 papers, one [23] had a section that shared the steps they took to safeguard participant anonymity, some of which were that they did not collect demographic data nor signatures for compensation receipt, waved documented consent, and welcomed participants to use pseudonyms. This approach may have been due to the uniqueness of the value of anonymity to this participant group. Hodge et al. in a section of their paper, question the concept of protection versus acknowledgment when working with persons with dementia. They discuss the robbing of the dignity and lives of persons with dementia using pseudonyms [24]. Four papers shared evidence that the process had been one of negotiation where participants had had the opportunity to choose to be identified by their real names [25–28]. Jo et al. mention in their paper the need for pseudonymization when working with parents [29]. Apart from the aforesaid papers, most work used the phrase “all names are pseudonyms” or variations of it with little to no background to the purpose, process, or allocation. This showed how the process of name re-assignment is rarely reported, discussed with participants, or seen as a negotiation of identity and power dynamics occurring between the researcher and the researched. The majority of papers did not explicitly acknowledge the power existent in the renaming process. Even when working with the marginalized, their names were erased, or they were assigned names not reflective of their backgrounds. In addition, this revealed that in HCI research, critical perspectives on pseudonymizing participants' names is an area of minimal research and discussion.

There is a gap in HCI literature on specific guidelines for the pseudonymization process and the ethical considerations for choosing names. The anonymity practice is silent and situated as a technical requirement (an established truth). The practice is then subject to the researcher. Researchers often choose to perform the activity when away from the participants, for example, when transcribing or annotating the data. Others may use software tools, for example a web tool, to generate alternative names based on birth year and gender [4]. Another less popular method would involve engaging participants in renaming themselves, enabling them to choose or informing them of the names they will be assigned with negotiations to what will be gained or lost in the process. This can be a process of acknowledging the power and privilege inherent in the process and being conscious of the inherent differences in values of the participants, researcher, and sponsoring organization.

As HCI grows in advocacy against oppressive technology and with growing interests in cross-cultural research, work with marginalized persons, and decolonizing computing, it is necessary that practices such as these, that are carried out conscientiously and mechanically are put out on the table for discussion. That we question the tools and guidelines we currently use and how representations of race, gender and ethnicity are erased in the work we do. For example, generating alternative names using the web tool mentioned above may work for persons with western names. What happens when the ethnicity and assigned races of researchers and participants differ? Have we considered the elements of racism at work when white researchers rename black participants and communities to white European names and communities? Are we

aware that renaming is more than a technical procedure and there is always a need to question the representations of names especially choosing names that capture cultural, or ethnonational associations of names [5]? Apparently, the find and replace approach (where participants names are queried in transcripts and replaced with alternatives) is now complex than ever [9]. How are participants disadvantaged by the pseudonymization process and how do we as researchers contribute to silencing already silenced voices? How can we move a step further from increasing representation by empowering our co-researchers/participants through every finite step of research? As my name represents my racial and ethnic identity, is my representation erased if I am assigned a western name? Why does research insistently assume the position of protection even when participants wish to be acknowledged as partners of research? Does renaming participants take away any essential values in contributing to key research?

3 THE THEORETICAL FRAMING

I choose critical theory specifically Critical Race Theory (CRT) as the theoretical basis for presenting my case. Delgado and Stefancic define CRT as a movement that questions the very foundations of the liberal order, including equality theory, legal reasoning, Enlightenment rationalism, and neutral principles of constitutional law [30]. While critical race theorists do not subscribe to a unified set of principles, several key tenets are prominent in their writings [15]. These tenets are that i. racism is ordinary, not aberrational, ii. race and racism are socially constructed, iii. Identity is intersectional iv. those with power rarely concede it without interest convergence, v. liberalism itself can hinder anti-racist progress, and vi. there is a uniqueness to the voice of color and storytelling is a means for it to be heard [15, 16, 30]. CRT desires research to question objectivity and truth, adding that there is no one way of conducting research or knowing but a process subject to the lens being used. In adopting CRT as a critical lens on the practice of renaming participants, I acknowledge that race as identity is intersectional and cannot be discussed wholly without other identity facets. I adopt CRT as a critical lens in starting conversations needed to unpack how marginalized communities in computing have been erased [20].

CRT in HCI research requires the community to persistently question ways of research as depictions of established truths relative to all persons. Do the ways of performing research matter to and represent all adequately without dehumanizing the persons involved? Are the established truths (formed based on the dominant culture by which all research is assessed) a furtherance of westernized or Eurocentric ways of knowing [17]? CRT in HCI means acknowledging representation, designing research while being other conscious and improving the numbers of minority participation [15]. In designing research, it is essential to consider the methodologies, knowledge systems and ways of knowing relevant or comfortable to participants. For example, CRT advances story telling as providing powerful counter stories that challenge majoritarian stories that make White privilege natural [16]. Additionally, when working with communities such as indigenous persons, their values must take precedence, facilitating voice and power in showcasing their stories and experiences in the chosen methodologies

of research [17, 18]. CRT in HCI requires essential reflection of the application of qualitative and quantitative methodologies and how they continually advance oppression and silencing. Acknowledging representation may not always be in increasing researcher representations but recognizing the participants representations and their historical relationships to white research. This means when working with marginalized groups, choosing to use the research as an opportunity to empower their representation and narrative. It means accepting all that they are and bring to the research, values, history, identity, health, etc. Being other and self-conscious when designing research will need researchers to see what they bring to the table, what or whose values, history, identity do they advance in the performance of their work. Is the research a statistic or does it effect change in the lives of the participants?

I particularly chose the "standard" process of renaming participants to illustrate how "everyday" contexts in the field can be vehicles of racial and ethnic oppressions. The act of renaming from the perspective of the name-giver has little to no significance and is rarely reflected upon. Ethnographers who did cross-cultural work have been criticized for renaming communities, persons, and places researched without cultural, historical, or human consideration [10]. This has led to communities such as the Menominee ensuring that researchers do not use pseudonyms to represent them but project their communities [31]. Tomaselli et al. in their work with indigenous communities criticize the fulfilment of ethical committees' requirements even when the concept is not of value to the participants. For example, ensuring participants append signatures of involvement even when the concept of signatures does not signify an affirmation of trust for that community [18]. And then there are the political histories behind the renaming of persons in contexts such as slavery and the holocaust, the power that was taken away from persons whose names were changed [21]. CRT methodologies call for inclusion and empowerment for all. A movement dedicated to projecting less heard voices while questioning the objectivity of research tools and techniques. Are pseudonyms being used to advance researchers' power and privilege, tell stories that participants may be unable to trace their contribution or receive recognition for? Are pseudonyms used to erase voices?

4 THE PERSONAL NARRATIVE

I am Akan. I belong to the Akan people found in countries such as Ghana and Ivory Coast. The system of naming in the Akan culture is not arbitrary but based on socio-cultural and ethno-pragmatic contexts [3]. In my culture, a name is deemed to have positive and negative effects on the person. My name Nana Kesewaa was given to me by my father. He named me after his grandmother, Kesewaa. Hence, I am a carrier of my grandmother's name, which is denoted by the Nana attached to my name. I am expected to carry myself honorably in society to uphold the person whose name was conferred unto me. This culture is similar to other cultures where, children quite literally wear their history in their names [32]. In the Akan culture, where the belief of re-incarnation exists, a naming ceremony is a sacred event held with significant rituals. Parents do not announce the name of their child until the ceremony. Due to the belief of the child being a visiting spirit, babies are referred

to by the day of the week they were born until the selected name is bestowed on them at the ceremony. When a baby is given this name, it is accepted as a new integral member of the community. To the knowledgeable, my name can speculate my country and town of origin, ethnic group, clan, and the language(s) I can speak. I am referred to by both (first) names though the Nana is used as a pet name by family and close relations.

Since living in a predominantly white western culture, in Germany, I have taken particular attention to the numerous instances where people have chosen to call me as they wished without asking or realizing the need for negotiation. Persons may misspell and/or mispronounce my name or assign my second first name and last name as my surname. This can only be rectified when I am asked. Persons assume and situate my name in Eurocentric definitions and contexts, knowing it all. It is an easy to single out foreigner's name. Being renamed without permission is characteristic of white supremacist and colonialist ideologies in naming lands and persons (discovered) as fitting to their standards, neglecting the names the communities had for those lands and persons. I was once advised by a white German woman while looking for a student job to consider changing my name, the name with all that cultural and family value to a German (Western) one, to fit in and increase my chances of being hired. This reflected the systemic discrimination against migrants whose names are evidence of their otherness. This renaming made me aware and brought to surface racial micro-aggressions in being referred to by names that were easier to call than my "difficult" name.

As an HCI researcher, I have had the privilege of working with persons from cultural backgrounds other than mine. Often, I have adopted the approach of renaming participants using alphabets and numbers: S-1, S-2 etc. to fulfil ethical requirements. I switched to assigning fake names to participants as was recommended to bring attention to the human perspective of the researched (from a subject to participant). My recent work with elderly white German women who lived alone included interviews which were transcribed and analyzed [33]. Taking a reflexive approach, and reflecting on my work, I suddenly became aware of the privilege I had ascribed to myself by renaming the women. I had renamed my participants using popular German names of women in a bid to protect them. The reflection process I took made me ask myself questions such as what I could have done better if I had been the participant. This were challenging reflections as race, culture, gender, and age were vital to the research. Nevertheless, when I imagined a researcher, a white researcher, changing my name to a German or western name, I knew it would mean erasing all that my name carried. And then again if the researcher chose to change my name to a Ghanaian one, as one living in a community predominantly white I could be easily linked to the information provided. Then again, how would they make this choice as any other Ghanaian name may not necessarily represent my ethnic, cultural, and family values. This I concluded would have to be an act needing negotiation. I would appreciate it if the researcher asked me what I wish to be called and we discussed how much of my cultural and ethnic representations I would like to be represented while ensuring my unique user experiences are captured.

In a related narrative, Michelle Brear, critically reflecting on their ethnography work with 10 black co-researchers from Swaziland

acknowledged the inherent racism and privilege that exists in the process of pseudonymizing participants (co-researchers). During the research, they made their participants aware that their names would be replaced by English names, though the co-researchers could give a preferred name if they wanted to. On reflecting on her work with colleagues, she realized the connotations of racism in the process of pseudonymizing and re-engaged the co-researchers on their given pseudonyms and asked if they wished to be re-assigned new names [7].

The interdependency of race, gender etc. to the researcher - researched relationship and to the research becomes clearer when roles are switched. While work conducted by white researchers may be noted as innovative, work by other races with whites may be judged otherwise or with their own races can be tagged as performing investigative work for whites. Many more black researchers are voicing out these interdependencies in carrying out research and how it differs when conducted by white researchers. [14].

I used this personal narrative with elements of autoethnography to emphasize the cultural and historic essence of a name, my name as an example and the role the pseudonymization practice could take in hiding it. I bring to emphasis the need for researchers to consider their backgrounds and how the research can be interpreted by the researched.

5 WAY FORWARD

I suggest these three recommendations to the HCI community for consideration. These recommendations address the conduct of research and pseudonymization and are initial steps in approaching the issue at hand. It is therefore open to further collective deliberations and (re)constructions. The recommendations presented do not follow a systematic order of progression.

First, I suggest the research activity or study should be set as a CRT movement with the goal to empower less heard voices. In planning research, research participants choice, research location, remuneration, skills to be imparted etc. should align with the goal of empowerment. This may mean having pre-research deliberations with participants and research stakeholders to identify what empowerment may entail for the participants. Researchers would need to avoid assuming what empowerment is for the participants. There should be discussions on the research activities that present opportunities to facilitate the empowerment of the voices in the study. In addition, participants should be educated on the power they bring to the table and their rights to exercise it. Participants should be empowered as equal partners in the process. This can be engaging participants in methodology choice. This might seem overstretched, but the engagement will raise positive and negative connections participants may have concerning the methodology. Empowerment will enable participants to leave the research activity better than they came in (better here as defined by the participants). This could be beneficial skills, the platform for facilitating discussions on challenges facing the group, money, etc. In designing research, researchers would need to be "self-conscious", aware of the power and privilege granted by race, societal hierarchy, gender, age etc. Researchers could declare their privilege as a possible conflict to the research goal and address this, particularly when working with participants with less privilege.

Secondly, I believe that to adequately set research goals as an empowerment movement, there needs a confronting of systems such as organizational and financial systems. I refer to systems that inherently facilitate oppression and inequalities. For example, in avoiding the use of pseudonyms, researchers may be challenged by Ethic boards and data protection requirements. Can organizational structures be modified to allow for participants' real names to be reported in research? How can current organizational structures support participant's desires for acknowledgement? How can "technicalities" that claim to protect participant identity be (re)structured to ensure less heard voices are enabled and their narratives protected? In conducting research as an empowerment movement, finance may play a key role in making this functional. This can be a challenge when sponsoring institutions prefer research projects with potential economic benefits. Finances regulate, restrict, and can modify research projects. For research groups that lack financial privilege, research goals as empowerment activities can be a challenge. I suggest that institutions with greater financial privilege collaborate with less financially privileged research groups for projects that ultimately lead to empowering participants.

The third recommendation focuses on the specifics of research and pseudonymization. When possible, researchers should identify and define research guidelines that represent the values of the researched community. What are the ethical values and representations of confidentiality and privacy of the group? There may be communities that due to negative past experiences with researchers, will need dedicated trust building processes. Additionally, researchers in dialog with participants can consider other creative forms of identity representation. This I envision could be sketches, glyphs, avatars, names of favorite fable characters or even tattoos. The process would be tailored to the specific group and yet make room for participant uniqueness. Most importantly when working with persons of color or racialized groups that suffer forms or histories of oppression from researcher's race, the research should identify the possible connotations for changing participants' names. Researchers should relinquish the privilege of renaming and engage in negotiation for identity representation.

6 CONCLUSION

I have in the paragraphs above presented the need to reflect on pseudonymization and consider it as a possible act of oppression and silencing. I present this paper as a case for starting the discussion on "objective" tenets of research established as truths, questioning the oppressive structures inherent in these practices. My main argument is that the HCI community needs to review so-called standard technical processes as they may advance oppression. The "one-size-fits-all" approach will end but with an awareness of the embedded prejudice in the tenets of what our work as researchers entails and a dedication to consistently reflect and change. We need to advance in methodologies centered on CRT that facilitate voice, power and agency of the persons who make our work possible. I call for an awareness of the differences in values, culture, history of the persons we work with. I hope that this paper will spark a critical (re)positioning that leads to addressing equality in design and research.

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